

Why Islam Forbids Alcohol

What the word means, what the Qur'an says, and what science found

1. The meaning of the words

The Arabic word: *Khamr* (خمر)

The Qur'an does not use the word "alcohol." It uses **khamr**, from the root **kh-m-r**, which means "**to cover**" or "**to veil**."

- A woman's head covering is called **khimār** (Qur'an 24:31). It comes from the same root, because it *covers*.
- Umar ibn al-Khattab** said: "*Khamr is whatever covers the mind.*" (Sahih al-Bukhari 5581)

So the name itself explains the ruling: khamr covers the mind, and a covered mind is an unguarded mind.

The English word: *Alcohol*

- "Alcohol" comes from the Arabic **al-kuḥl** (الكحل), the fine black powder used as eyeliner (kohl).
- Medieval alchemists used the word for any very fine, purified *essence*. Later, "alcohol of wine" meant the purified essence of wine, and the name stuck.
- Strong drinks are called "**spirits**" because the alchemists thought the vapor they distilled was the *spirit* (essence) of the liquid.

Honesty note: A popular internet claim says "alcohol" comes from *al-ghoul* (an evil spirit that eats bodies). **That is not true.** Etymology dictionaries trace it to *al-kuḥl*. If we use a false claim and it is checked later, people may doubt everything else we said. **The true meaning, khamr = "that which covers the mind," is stronger anyway.**

2. What the Qur'an says

Qur'an 5:90-91 (the final ruling):

"O you who believe! Intoxicants, gambling, idols, and divining arrows are **filth from the work of Shayṭān**, so avoid them so that you may succeed. **Shayṭān only wants** to cause hostility and hatred between you through intoxicants and gambling, and **to turn you away from the remembrance of Allah and from prayer**. So will you not stop?"

Allah Himself links alcohol to **Shayṭān** in three ways:

- It is **from his work**.
- He uses it to **cause fights and hatred**.
- He uses it to **block dhikr (remembrance of Allah) and salah**.

3. How this "opens the door" to Shayṭān

This is the spiritual link, built only on the texts:

Step	Source
1 Alcohol covers the mind .	Umar, Bukhari 5581
2 It blocks remembrance of Allah and prayer .	Qur'an 5:91
3 Whoever turns away from remembrance of the Most Merciful, "We appoint for him a devil, and he becomes his companion."	Qur'an 43:36
4 While a person is drinking, īmān (faith) is not in them . <i>"The drinker is not a believer at the time he drinks."</i>	Bukhari 2475, Muslim 57

Dhikr, prayer, and a clear mind are a Muslim's protection. Alcohol takes all three away at once. When the guard leaves, Shayṭān gets closer.

That is why the companion Uthman ibn Affan (may Allah be pleased with him) called it:

"Umm al-khabā'ith": the mother of all evils.

Sunan an-Nasa'i 5666. A similar wording is also reported from the Prophet (peace be upon him).

It is called "the mother" because it leads to the other sins: anger, zina, violence, lying, and leaving salah.

Scholars do discuss jinn affecting people, but no authentic text says one drink puts a spirit inside the body. The accurate teaching is the one above: alcohol removes your protection and brings Shayṭān near.

4. What modern science confirms

- **World Health Organization (2023):** *"No level of alcohol consumption is safe for our health."*
- Alcohol is a **Group 1 carcinogen**, the same category as tobacco. It is linked to at least 7 cancers, including **breast cancer** (IARC/WHO).
- About **2.6 million deaths every year** worldwide are caused by alcohol (WHO, 2024).
- Alcohol first slows the **prefrontal cortex**, the part of the brain for judgment and self-control. **Science is describing khamr, "covering the mind," in modern words.**

The Qur'an also admits that it has some benefit, but says **"their sin is greater than their benefit"** (2:219). This is honest and balanced, and it matches the data.

5. A message of mercy (the most important part)

Allah did **not** forbid alcohol all at once. It came in **stages**:

1

Qur'an 2:219

It has more harm than
benefit.

2

Qur'an 4:43

Do not come to prayer
while intoxicated.

3

Qur'an 5:90

Avoid it completely.

Aisha (may Allah be pleased with her) said: *"If the first thing revealed had been 'Do not drink wine,' people would have said, 'We will never leave wine.'"* (Bukhari 4993)

Allah was patient with the first Muslims, so we should be patient with each other.

Leaving it is a journey, and every step counts. The door of tawbah (repentance) is always open:

"Say: O My servants who have wronged themselves, do not despair of the mercy of Allah." (Qur'an 39:53)

In one sentence

Khamr means "what covers the mind." A covered mind forgets Allah, and a heart that forgets Allah is left open to Shayṭān. That is why Allah called it "the work of Shayṭān," and why the early Muslims called it "the mother of all evils." Allah also made leaving it gradual and full of mercy.